8 From position- to issue-driven collaborations between the humanities and business: The case of "Eat it, and save it"

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Introduction

As a contribution to the field of business anthropology, this chapter lays out what I term an issue-driven approach to collaborations between the humanities and business. This issue-driven approach is developed through a consultancy project that I was engaged in, and which was to formulate recommendations on how to scale a new food concept. The main ingredients making up the food items in this new food concept are all produced by cultivating Danish heirloom livestock and crops, enabling consumers to partake in the preservation of these heirloom livestock and crops by buying and consuming these food items. "Eat it, and save it", as one tagline for the concept read. As cultural analytical consultants, we, my then business partner and I, interviewed ten Danish households on their food consumption practices, and during these interviews we asked the ten households to develop further the new food concept with us. Our client, a conglomerate of food producers and businesses, researchers, and civil society organisations, and we, the consultants, all supported the main idea guiding the development of this new food concept. As Søren, a member of one of the ten households interviewed and who we will meet again a little later, put it: "This is crazy important – biodiversity is crazy important!" We all supported the idea because it is an example of how we might begin handling the current environmental devastations in our everyday lives. We shared and sought to enact participation in an issue of public concern – the pending climate, environmental, and biodiversity crisis – situated in everyday food consumption practices. And we all did our best to make this participation as strong and impactful as possible through our different ways of thinking, working, eating, living, and relating. This collaborative effort to handle an issue of public concern lies at the heart of the issue-driven approach. In the closing of this chapter, I offer four tips on how to engage with and develop further this issue-driven approach.

It is also this situated and collaborative participation in an issue of public concern that sets this approach apart from the approaches detailed in the existing body of literature produced within the academic field of business

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anthropology (Jordan, 2012). This existing body of literature primarily discusses the positioning of the anthropologist vis-à-vis business or businesses. Anthropologist Daniela M. Peluso, for instance, distinguishes between an anthropology *of* business (which she also terms *non-consultant anthropology*), and an anthropology *for* business (which she also terms *consultancy anthropology*) (Peluso, 2017; see also Denny and Sunderland, 2016). Anthropology of business has produced a wide range of insightful ethnographies on how businesses operate (examples include Law, 1994; Moeran, 1996; Ho, 2009; and Krause-Jensen, 2010), while anthropology for business is a more scattered subfield as succinctly described by anthropologist Melissa Cefkin in the introduction to her edited volume *Ethnography and the Corporate Encounter*: "Neither a "how-to-book" in applied anthropology, nor one of angst-ridden wringing about practitioners moral and political complicity, the aim of this volume is, nonetheless, to explore and expose the very complex conditions of this work" (Cefkin et al., 2010, p. 2). Further prepositional referents have been added to the mix – anthropologists can also work *with*, *in* or *outside* of business or businesses, Peluso mentions (Peluso, 2017, p. 19). Transparency in positioning is important always, everywhere, and in all kinds of cultural analytical work. But if we can agree, as Peluso also states, that "business and businesses are now, more than ever, becoming increasingly recognized by the public as part of our socio-cultural, economic and political lives" (Peluso, 2017, p. 11), then we need to re-think this positioning. Not only do we need to position ourselves vis-à-vis business and businesses but also understand ourself as always already deeply entangled in the issues of public concern which business and businesses take part in enacting through their doings. Anthropologist Lucy Suchman, who pioneered the uptake of anthropological modes of working in business settings (see, for instance, Suchman, 1983), makes a similar point, describing how the anthropologist is also positioned in business or businesses. The interest in anthropology from business, Suchman contends, "involves the anthropologist herself in an identity marked as exotic other within the context of commercial and technological worlds: an other brought home to live inside and become part of the enterprise" (Suchman, 2007, p. 1, see also Suchman, 2013). The effect of these dual practices of positioning is that both business and the humanities are caught up in and continue to reinforce their different identities rather than exploring what they might accomplish together. The argument is not that the humanities should be eaten by businesses to save themselves or vice versa. The argument is that we need to find ways of collaborating, in which such different ways of thinking and working are brought into play in handling issues of public concern. We need to leave the prevailing position-driven approach behind and, instead, begin to flesh out an issue-driven approach to planning, executing, and scaling collaborations comprising the humanities and business. Following this, my aim here is to begin answering the following

explorative question: How can the humanities and business begin to handle issues of public concern – in this case sustainable transitions – together?

Interviews and analyses powered by material participation

In the following text, I will re-tell some of the stories about food consumption that the ten households told us. To re-tell stories is not only a matter of stating the facts. It is an analytical exercise, which is powered by the notion of material participation developed in a number of publications by sociologist and key contributor to the field of science and technology studies, Noortje Marres (2012a,b, 2011; Marres and Lezaun, 2011). Marres explores "how the project of 'letting things in' *transforms* a specific category of social and political life, that of participation" (Marres, 2012b, p. 1, italics in original). Commonly, we regard participation in issues of public concern as an out of the ordinary practice – voting in a voting booth, or protesting in the streets, for instance. Letting everyday things into the equation, however, not only extends these existing forms of participation but enables a new form of participation, Marres argues, to potentially be enacted in material everyday practices. Material participation, thus, is a form of participation in issues of public concern that may be enacted in material everyday practices. To give an example from another of the ten household interviews: Like Søren, Jakob is in his early 30s. It would annoy him to be called a foodie but his girlfriend, Soheila, tells us that he – at times – is somewhat stressed out over all the food experiments he has to tend to in their apartment. And he shops for food – daily. During the interview, we give him one of the food items in the new food concept, a sausage: "OK, if that sausage had been lying next to the one, I bought in the supermarket yesterday, I would have picked that one! I could have told my son about it – that it matters what we eat – it's a real nice concept!" The analytical point being, that if the sausage had been right there in that moment – yesterday in the supermarket fridge for sausages – then it would have become part of Jakob's daily shopping practice, and it would have become a social and political actor, taking part in enacting a specific version of participation in the issue of sustainable living. It makes sense, then, to regard everyday practice not only as social, but socio-material. A form of participation that is more fleeting than most democratic votes, quieter than a protest in the streets. A form of participation that, however, is a collective achievement – enacted through entanglements of people and things, entanglements of business opportunities like the sausage, and caring for one's child and our planet through the self-same sausage.

As all the food items in the new food concept are organically produced, that conglomerate found it best to interview households that had a positive attitude towards organic farming.[1] Further, the conglomerate asked for diversity in the households' constitution – two single households, two

households of couples with no kids, four households of couples with kids living at home, and two households of couples whose kids had left the nest. And, further, we, the consultants, were asked to ensure geographical diversity in where the households had their homes.[2]

The issue-driven approach to collaborations between the humanities and business cares about and is cared for by enactments of material participation as exemplified by the sausage in the aforementioned example. The specific way we set up and conducted our interviews illustrates this point on mutual care. We insisted on conducting the interviews in the homes of the ten households, as, following Marres, the home is a prominent site for the enactment of material participation. Each interview lasted between 1, 3, and 5 hours. The rather long interviews enabled our interlocutors and us ample time to not only factually map the household's food consumption practices but also construct a mutual understanding of the households' varied ways of (not) partaking in sustainable transitions as an issue of public concern. For instance, Soheila, whom we will also meet a little later, told us, that she and her girlfriends share tips on more sustainable householding via snaps on Snapchat. We took photographs of the households' kitchens to add to our understanding of householding as a socio-material practice. And we brought exemplars of the food items – including the promotional storytelling materials also developed by the conglomerate – with us and into the homes of our household interlocutors. We let the members of the households see, touch, and smell the food items, and we read the storytelling materials out loud for the household members. All of this enabled our household interlocutors to act as co-designers (Sanders and Stappers, 2014; Sanders, 2006; Binder and Brandt, 2008; Mattelmäki, 2005) of the next version of the new food concept.

Routines

In our analysis of the empirical materials generated through the interviews we asked: How might the new food items become part of the households' everyday practices? When, where, how, and why? And what kinds of value and values could the food items take part in enacting there and then? The response from the empirical materials was univocal: The households suggested less alluring storytelling and more information about how the preservation work took place, and why, more exactly, the conglomerate is engaged in this preservation work. The food items and the storytelling materials, in other words, allow for the households to act as citizens engaging in what may constitute "good" food items and their production, rather than consumers seduced by the storytelling materials. Digging analytically deeper into the stories told by our household interlocutors, it became clear that the scaling of the food item relevant axis of difference was not between the households but between three different kinds of food consumption practices shared by all the households. That is, the establishing

of food consumption routines, the conducting of experiments in food consumption, and the planning of events in which food and food consumption plays a significant role. The point being that in formulating recommendations for how the new food concept can be scaled, we could take our point of departure in these practices of establishing routines, conducting experiments, and planning events. I lay out this analytical result in more detail later.

For three years, Bente, 66, and Torben, 70, have lived full-time in their summer cottage in Odsherred, Northwest Zealand, Denmark. They decided to retire, which prompted them to give up their first home – an apartment in a Copenhagen satellite city. They support the local business community in their food purchases and when shopping for other necessities. As Bente explains: "You can shop cheaper elsewhere. Nevertheless, now that we have decided to live here, it is reassuring to know the local shops. By now, the local shops also know our needs". During the summer, they buy essential items from the ultra-local grocery store. That store is open only during the warmer months when more people live in or rent the area's many summer cottages. However, the range of the ultra-local grocery store does not always live up to the couple's standards of freshness and variety. They go to a less local supermarket instead. It has a much broader range of fresh, organic goods. "But we don't like the potential implications of the small shops closing – that isn't good for life in the area", Torben contends.



Bente and Torben usually go food shopping together, and their trips follow a somewhat fixed route through the local shops. In addition to shopping locally, they go for organic food items. At the local bakery, they buy their organic bread. They purchase cold cuts and cheeses at their local farmer's market. They shop there weekly. And they like this farmer's market a lot. Torben always chats with the owner, who is, like Torben,

from Southern Jutland. Their assortment includes a specific sausage that reminds Torben of the one he got when he was a child growing up in Southern Jutland. Freshly caught fish is their favourite summer food, and they buy it at the local harbour's fishmonger. "We chat with that owner, too", Bente chips in.

These routines, however, are not set in stone, and they are not followed mindlessly by Bente and Torben. "When it's possible to buy organic, I will gladly do so", Bente says, hinting that the shops she visits do not always support her desire to buy organically produced food items. With a twinkle in her eye, she adds: "Torben is from Southern Jutland", a region of Denmark known for its slightly stingy citizens, "so he also looks at the price". Torben responds: "I don't mind organically produced foodstuffs, but I also know that organic farming is not always the most sustainable way of producing food". Torben's knowledge of farming, and his price awareness, question their routine of buying organically. They like the liver pate from the local supermarket better than the one sold at the farmer's market. A specific industrially produced jam has a taste that, according to Torben, "no one can beat". "We have tried the locally grown, organic lambs. The meat was way too fatty for our taste. We don't buy that anymore", Torben says, Bente nodding. Organically and locally produced food items are often promoted as tasting better. Bente and Torben sometimes disagree, questioning their routines of buying locally and organically.

Consumer values are often understood to dictate consumer behaviour (Shove, 2010). Attending to practices – in this case, the food shopping practices of Bente and Torben – destabilises this believed causality between values and behaviour. The food shopping practices of Bente and Torben do not only comprise their values of shopping locally and organically. The assortments of various shops, childhood memories, price comparisons, knowledge of farming, a chatty owner of a farmer's market, a nearby harbour, tastes, and the fat content of a piece of lamb meat all partake in enabling Bente and Torben to become engaged in what to them constitutes good food shopping practices. While these, to Bente and Torben, 'good' food shopping practices are largely routinised, they also engage in experiments. The purchasing of the locally and organically cultivated lamb meat is the example put into words by Bente and Torben. Their attachment to a specific liver pate and jam is another example of an outcome of their experiments. In the case of Bente and Torben, experiments do not always lead to the establishment of new routines, even though these experiments could result in routines more in line with their values of buying locally and organically. Consumer values do not dictate behaviour. Instead, consumer values are continuously reinforced, reinterpreted, and reconfigured in and through the consumption practices carried by human consumers and enabled by a wide range of more than human actors.

Bente and Torben's stories about their food consumption practices were the ones that most forcefully put routines in the driving seat. The members

of the following Copenhagen-based household, Sohelia, 34, Jakob, 31, and their child, Hetav, 2, told similar stories of routines. Jakob also told us many detailed stories of his experiments in more sustainable food preparation.

Experiments

Jakob is the primary food shopper and preparer in this household. For instance, he bakes all of the family's bread. He keeps his sourdoughs alive and well. He has been baking for a few years now, gradually becoming more proficient. He has acquired a mixer and is constantly trying to refine his bread making. He finds recipes online and compares his bread with bread from niche and high-quality bakeries. Furthermore, he has experimented with several different types of flour, and he thinks that he is approaching the perfect bread. He recently started using flour with a very high content of gluten, which makes a crucial difference to him. The high-gluten flour is produced at a specific mill: "You know all those health shops. They sell organic flour produced responsibly, but the gluten content is low. You can hardly bake with that type of flour alone. Then I think it's a bad product! On the other hand, this flour, from that specific mill – it's fantastic! It has an enormously high content of gluten!"

For Jakob, baking the family's bread is not a routine but an open-ended project of continuous experimenting. The purpose of these experiments is to – one fine day – pull the perfect loaf out of the oven. It is telling that Jakob says he is almost at the finishing line but not quite there yet. If he did reach his goal, his baking would lose its value as it is the succeeding experiments that make baking a meaningful practice for Jakob.

Jakob's experiments go well beyond baking bread. He is currently reading a guide to fermentation and experiments with making soy-like products and miso from Danish ingredients such as yellow peas and squid leftovers from the local fishmonger. He experiments pickling edible plants and their fruits foraged in and around Copenhagen. He has been brewing beer with a friend for a long time – not the same beer twice, however. He often eats out with family and friends, and on Instagram, he follows his favourite restaurants and chefs: "I use restaurants and social media to get inspiration. I follow the head of NOMA's fermentation work, for instance. And I follow a guy in England who is creating the first restaurant in the world that is 'zero-waste'".

Few aspects of Jakob's food preparation practices are routinised. To get things done – to get food shopping and preparing – done better requires experimentation. Nevertheless, there are limits. To experiment constantly, at every time and in every place is exhausting. Too exhausting. This point is made by Jakob's wife, Soheila. She tells us that Jakob's "tending to all of his experiments at a point became a bit much". A bit much as in taking too much focus away from other and equally important everyday householding tasks and concerns. The solution: the couple has agreed to curb Jakob's food

experiments a bit. The couple has achieved this by implementing a weekly meal plan. The vegetables they receive every Monday from the vegetable community they have just joined work as the starting point for this weekly meal planning.



In the case of Bente and Torben, experiments in shopping for and preparing food in line with their values – at times – effected a solidification of routines not in line with their values. As we just saw in the case of Jakob and Sohelia, the stress of experimenting can also result in implementing new kinds of routines, exemplified through the implementation of weekly meal planning. Values can be too exhausting to keep in practice – here, Jakob's dedication to experiments in how the household can come to eat more sustainably and more deliciously. Values do not precede practice – values are enacted in practice. But so is stress, for instance, paving the way for compromising values, the routine of a weekly meal plan, for example, to be enacted in the same go.

The inspiration for Jakob's food experiments comes from common everyday sources such as books and Instagram and from extraordinary events such as eating at restaurants that match Jakob's dedication to experimenting. The planning of a food-related event, a wedding, was on Søren's mind when we interviewed him as a representative of the household run by him and his fiancé.

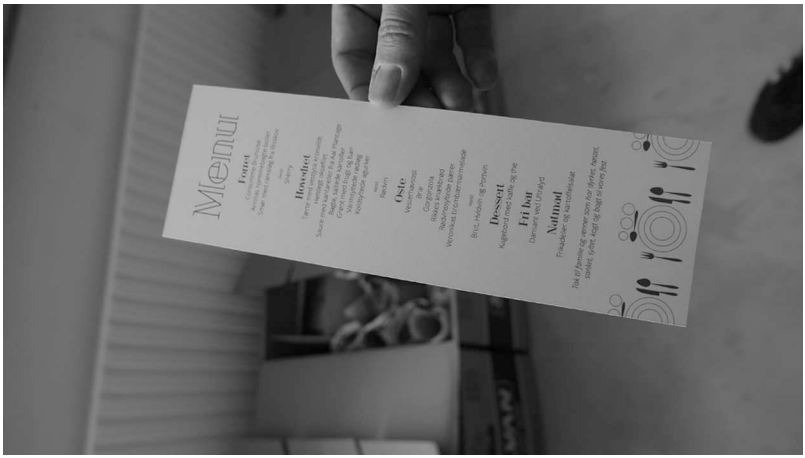
Events

Recently, Maja, 31, and Søren, 39, moved from a small apartment in Denmark's second-largest city, Aarhus, to a small town located in the Central Denmark Region. The area's beautiful landscape sparked the idea of moving: "5 years ago, I drove through the landscape and thought to myself: 'Shit, this is nice!'" Søren tells us. This move implies a change in the

material setting in which Søren does his food shopping. Søren explains: "In Aarhus, we subscribed to a bag of vegetables delivered every week. The bag was a point of departure for my food preparations. We were only two people then, and we were not good at planning our meals. We shopped almost every day. Also, to avoid packaging, we bought dry goods in a shop where you can bring your own containers. I miss the delicious supermarkets in Aarhus. I like to shop for food in supermarkets that give me aesthetic pleasure". Now, the couple is expecting a child. And, as hinted at by Søren, this demands a bit more planning. "Today I'm preparing apple porridge with apples harvested from the apple tree in our new garden. I'm going to put it in the freezer. Then that's ready for when the baby arrives", Søren explains.

When entering Maja and Søren's new home, we notice the flower and herb bouquets decoratively placed on their dining table. "Last night, we had a rehearsal dinner for our wedding. The flowers and herbs are all edible", Søren excitedly tells us.

Maja and Søren have decided that their wedding will be celebrated by gathering family and friends in a large scout's cabin in the scenic Mols Bjerge National Park. In their everyday lives, they focus on sustainable eating, and they bring this focus with them into the planning of their wedding. They engage family and friends in gathering, growing, pickling, and baking for the wedding party.



Søren's parents collect chanterelles at Ål Plantage in Oksbøl, a small town in West Jutland. Maja's brother will bring various berries from his garden outside of Aarhus. Maja's father provides fresh, home-grown vegetables and blackberries foraged in an area close to his home. The beef roast served as the main course is a product of the forest cattle that do nature conservation in the nearby national park. Maja and Søren have asked a local pizzeria to preserve glass containers, initially holding pickles, and donate them to the

wedding. A tea light is placed in each of them and spreads cosiness during the wedding party.

In Maja and Søren's everyday life, a pregnancy sparks new routines into being – with a helping hand from the fruits of the new garden's old apple tree. As we also saw in the case of Bente and Torben, establishing new routines is not a purely human or social feat. More than human actors – the fat content of a piece of lamb, for example – chime in as well. Like Jakob, Søren conducts experiments on where to buy what kinds of groceries. We learn that a focus on sustainable food consumption – a subscription to a bag of locally and organically produced vegetables and bringing your containers to a shop to avoid packaging – can go hand in hand with the enjoyment of entering a traditional supermarket designed to give Søren and aesthetic experience. Then, experiments in sustainable eating can be supported or disturbed by other everyday concerns – aesthetic pleasure being the example here. Food-related events – Bente and Torben mentioned visits from friends, their grown children, and their grandchildren, Jakob highlighted eating out with family and friends, Søren gave us a detailed account of the planning of the upcoming wedding – connect the specific food consumption practices of specific households to the specific food consumption practices of other specific households. We, the consultants, were not invited to Maja and Søren's wedding. And we, the consultants, do not have accounts of what happened at the wedding. However, Maja and Søren's specific way of planning their wedding does suggest that a wedding does not have to be "plug-and-play" at an expensive restaurant to be successful. They demonstrate to everyone involved how parties can be held more sustainably. Isn't the talk at the tables during the party going to be about just that – a more sustainable way of celebrating? At least some of the time, we suspect. And doesn't that talk give rise to new experiments and routines in more sustainable everyday food consumption among the guests and their households? At least in some of these households, I am sure.

Business–humanities collaborations caring for and taken care of by issues

In the preceding text, I have fleshed out how three Danish households seek to handle the issue of bringing into being practices of more sustainable eating and living. I have suggested that this handling takes place through routines, experiments, and events. Routines, experiments, and events in and through which humans and more than humans, values and practices, and the households of family and friends become entangled, and specific forms of material participation in sustainable living may be enacted.

In our, the consultants', final report, the first few pages are dedicated to an executive summary. We write:

> Transitions to more sustainable ways of consuming food are already taking place in organically-oriented households. That is good news for

> the new food concept! To contribute to the preserving and enhancing of not just Denmark's, but the Earth's biodiversity is regarded as extremely meaningful to all of our fieldwork interlocutors. The preserving and enhancing of biodiversity is by our interlocutors seen as part of the transition to living more sustainable everyday lives. The new food concept and its products thus meet households and everyday lives, where sustainability is already practiced through new routines, experiments, and events.

Unsurprisingly, the conglomerate was thrilled about this conclusion. Our issue- and practice-oriented household interviews also enabled us locate where, when, how, why, and with whom and what the ten households seek to enact sustainable transitions in their everyday practices. The supermarket, the kitchen, the farm shop, the restaurant, the internet, and the Danish natural and cultural landscape stood out as concrete settings – in all their socio-materialitiy and multi-speciesness – in which new kinds of routines, experiments, and events were imagined and brought to life. Thus, our recommendations to the conglomerate focused on how to bring the new food concept into these settings. While the conglomerate so far had focused on traditional storytelling – telling alluring stories to potential consumers about the history of the products in the new food concept – the households stressed that they would like more factual information about how the products are produced and why the food producers engage in the new food concept. This demand for more knowledge about "the hows" and "the whys" of the new food concept can be understood as a wish from the households to enrol this knowledge in their experiments in more sustainable living, which subsequently may lead to establishing more sustainable routines and events.

During the course of this consultancy project, the conglomerate was not the only business actors we encountered. The households interviewed made numerous references to farmer's markets and supermarkets, to food brands and restaurants, to social media companies, and food-related events and attractions. The households also made references to concepts and modes of analysis from our world, the world of humanities research. Some of our household interlocutors, for instance, discussed the wordings and the colours of the storytelling materials, turning the interviews into what resembled a class in semiotic analyses. Annette, 44, wife, mother to two boys, and living with her family in a townhouse in central Copenhagen, said about one paragraph: "It's incomprehensible – what is this all about? To me, this isn't clear communication!" Other household interlocutors engaged in philosophical discussions of the culture–nature divide requested clearer answers as to how the new food concept handles this divide. "Livestock and crops require people to be preserved. And if we then buy and eat these products, then we can create basis for further breeding and thus preserve biodiversity for the future.

That's fine – that's a good product!" Sofie, a single woman in her early 40s living in a small apartment in central Copenhagen, told us. She continues: "But they also mention nature's wild species. I don't understand it … Are the wild species living on their own in nature also endangered? Or do they do well in nature? What are the wild species in nature? Is it not possible that the wild species in nature need human intervention as well? And are there truly wild species in nature at all?" Sofie asks almost philosophically. Yet other interlocutors discussed with us which consumer segments the new food concept would be attractive to. For instance, a single woman in her late 40s living on her own in a house just outside of Copenhagen, told us: "I'm definitely part of the segment that the concept attempts to address. And I do think it's a good and important project. But when I see the flyer, I think it's something from the local pizzeria. That confuses me".

In the everyday routines, experiments, and events that the households interviewed engage in, the humanities and business not only meet. Concepts and modes of analysis from the humanities and business become deeply entangled in the handling of the issue of how to eat and live more sustainably. These entanglements – entanglements that we, the consultants, were drawn into – make it impossible to determine whether the present consultancy project was a humanities project of, for, with, in, or outside business. Instead, we started from the middle (Latour, 2005). That is, from how the issue of how participation in sustainable eating is enacted across the humanities, business, and many more actors, and we sought to find out when, where, and how the new food concept could come to support such enactments. In doing so, we empirically and analytically sought to care for the enactments of material participation already taking place in the ten households, and we, the consultants, were taken care of by the ten households' willingness to tell us their stories of how humanities and business interweave in their routines, experiments, and events of sustainable eating and living.

To practice what the issue-driven approach preaches

In closing the present chapter, I offer four practical tips intended to aid the humanities researcher keen to try out and, hopefully, develop further the issue-driven approach to collaborations between the humanities and business sketched out here.

Most collaborations between the humanities and business are organised as projects. Projects are defined by having a beginning and an end, that is, they are scoped, planned, executed, and accounted for. So, how does a humanities researcher take an issue-driven approach to the scoping, planning, executing, and accounting of project that involves the humanities and business?

Scoping: What is the issue?

When attending project scoping meetings with business, I urge the humanities researcher to suspend a priori assumptions about fundamental differences between the world of humanities research and the world of business operations. Such assumptions, as we have seen, nurture the position- and identity-driven approach, which – at best – led to collaborative projects where the value crated by the humanities researcher is one of tokenism rather than handling of issues of public concern. Instead, I recommend that the humanities researcher focuses on establishing what the project partners' shared issue of concern might be. This can be accomplished by asking the businesses to give a detailed account of their existing knowledge about how their products and services are made sense of put to use today by their customers and to what kinds of effects. Focusing on the production rather than consumption of the businesses' product and services works the same way: How are your products and services produced today and to what kinds of effects?

Planning: What is the research question?

The humanities bring concepts into the world that tell us something about humans as "thinking, creative, and acting beings" (Bille et al., 2019, p. 18, my translation). That is the object of study of the humanities – humans as thinking, creative, and active beings. Businesses, however, bring products and services into the world and these products and services aid or discourage humans to become thinking, creative, and active beings. Bringing the food items of the new food concept with us and into the homes of our household interlocutors, for instance, aided the human members of the ten households interviewed in thinking creatively and actively participating in making sense of developing further the new food concept. Humans are not thinking, creative, or active in an empty space – things and technologies, materialities and matters aid humans in becoming so. Therefore, when planning a collaborative humanities–business project, I suggest to formulate research questions that seek to answer when, where, how, with what, and why humans (and non-humans for that matter) become thinking, active, and creative beings, rather than making the premature assumption that this is the case always and everywhere. Taking an issue-driven approach to humanities–business collaborations, thus, entails formulating research questions that seek to illuminate on how humans (and non-humans, for that matter) become social and political actors in situated, socio-material practices and to what kinds of effects. In analysing these effects – and their "goods" and "bads" (see, for instance, Heuts and Mol, 2013; Mol, 2006; and Mol, 1999) – the analytical power of diverse disciplines within the humanities is utterly needed.

Executing: What's the collaboration?

Answering research questions on how humans become thinking, creative, and active beings is difficult to answer without inquiring deeply into the products and services produced by business. Such research questions, thus, lend themselves easily to collaborative empirical explorations and collaborative analyses of the empirical materials worked up through such explorations. To reap the fruits of an issue-driven approach, I urge the humanities researcher to invite the collaborators from business into the humanities researcher's practical work of gathering and generating empirical materials and the practical work of analysing these empirical materials. In executing the consultancy project, we, the consultants, only did so through meetings in which we discussed the advances of the project with a representative of the conglomerate. We did not, for instance, conduct parts of our fieldwork with the representative, and neither did we share our frustrations when we were not able to make analytical sense of the stories told to us by the households involved. We were preoccupied, which demonstrates that cultural analytical work does have something to offer. A preoccupation that is not in line with the issue-driven approach to humanities–business collaborations. I see a need for developing practical collaboration formats, which can bring humanities and business knowledge and competencies together in illuminating the forming and handling of issues of public concerns. Again, the argument is not to conflate the humanities and business but to enable better handling of issues of public concern together. This could, for instance, be achieved by importing and re-appropriating the methodologies from the field of co-design that subscribes to relational ontologies similar to the ones I have put to work in the present chapter (see, for instance, Escobar, 2018; Storni et al., 2015; and Latour, 2008).

Accounting: What's the story?

The story about the consultancy project that I have told here is not to be understood as *the* story about the consultancy project. I have chosen to tell *a* story about "throwntogetherness" (Massey, 2005, p. 181), and how this throwntogetherness was brought about and handled in the consultancy project. I could have told stories about "thrownapartness". For instance, the carving out of our object of study entailed heated and frustrating negotiations with the representative from the conglomerate as the representative had difficulties with the de-centreing of the human actors, which our issue-oriented approach entailed. Remember the quote by Melissa Cefkin in the introduction? Cefkin wrote that the aim of her edited volume was to expose the very complex conditions under which anthropologists in business work. My aim with this chapter has been related, yet different: I have sought to unpack the very complex conditions through which the

humanities and business may come to understand and handle issues of public concern better. The issue-driven approach yields issue-driven stories. Stories that focus less on differences in who or what we are, and more, and what we all – "we" in the broadest meaning possible – might be able to achieve together.

Conclusions

In the present chapter, I have sketched the contours of what I have termed an *issue-driven approach* to collaboration between the humanities and business. This issue-driven approach is necessitated by the fact that the humanities and business are already deeply entangled. Knowledge and concepts developed by the humanities are picked up and put to work by business, and, vice versa, it is difficult to imagine the humanities working and working well without aid from products and services produced and sold by business. While the prevailing position-driven approach to humanities–business collaborations seeks to disentangle the humanities form business, the issue-driven approach formulates and explores research questions on how such entanglements form issues of public concern and how such issues of public concern may be handled together. The issue-driven approach – its core workings – were developed through a consultancy project which was to formulate recommendation of how a new food concept can be scaled. To end the chapter – and to hopefully enable humanities researches to experiment with and develop further this issue-driven approach – I have formulated four practical tips for the humanities scholar entering into collaborations with business: gain insights on the effects of the production and consumption of the business products and services, formulate research questions are best answered together, find practical ways of letting the collaborating business into the workshops of the humanities, and, finally, consider to tell stories of thrown*together*ness rather than "thrown*apart*ness".

Notes

1 The assumption that it would yield the most useful analytical results to interview households who had a pre-existing interest in organically produced food items can be questioned. For instance, and as we will see in the analyses, some of the households questioned the connection between organic and sustainable farming. This questioning might raise another question, that is, whether this new food concept is – in effect – able to enrich diversity in crops and livestock in a (or at least the most) sustainable way? This points to material participation being situated in everyday practices where other kinds of concerns, for instance, that organically farmed produce may be better for human health than their traditionally produced counterparts, may trump sustainable eating and living. Material participation is not "good" always and everywhere – it "brings with it particular problems, aspirations and indeed ideals", Marres states (Marres, 2012b, p. 1). I do see it as a "good", however, to understand such problems better to enact more impactful modes of

participation in sustainable living. This goes for the humanities and for business and therefore the enactment of material participation can become a third space of collaboration (Muller 2007) for the humanities and business.

2 This deeply heteronormative attempt at representing different constellations of Danish households was not lost on us, the consultants, but we decided that this was not the time nor the place to fight that battle. Further, geographical location did not seem to have any significant say in the households' food consumption practices and their responses to the new food concept. In hindsight, to the aim of scaling the new food concept a more giving attempt at representation would have been to focus on diversity in how the households' food consumption practices are coded. As the analysis will show, we suggested that the new food concept relevant coding is whether the households' food consumption practice are primarily routinised, subject to open-ended experimenting, or driven by events. This analytical result stresses the importance of not mindlessly importing classic demographic variables into qualitative research, and it stresses the urgency of developing post-demographic approaches further (see, for instance, Mackenzie, 2016 and Rogers, 2009).

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